

Are all evangelists?

exposing the fallacy of universal evangelistic mandates

Have you ever wondered where the explosion of “false converts” came from in the last century or two? Have you considered that they might be the result of errors of the Church itself? **2Thess 2:3** is clear that there will be a “*falling away*” or *apostasy* (departure from truth) before the Antichrist is revealed. That falling away is talking about **the body of Christ itself departing from the truth** (cf. **1Ti 4:1-3**)!

When wondering “how could the Church possibly do such a thing?” the idea for this study came to mind. The technically precise evidence you will see in this study makes it overwhelmingly obvious that this is one way that the Church has already departed from the truth. And if the Church has already departed from the truth then the *falling away* has already begun.

Foundational Principle

Romans 12:4-8

⁴ For as we have many members in one body, and **all members have not the same office** ^{G4234}:

⁵ So we, being many, are one body in Christ, and every one members one of another.

⁶ Having then gifts differing according to **the grace that is given to us**, whether prophecy, let us prophesy according to the proportion of faith;

⁷ Or ministry, let us wait on our ministering: or he that teacheth, on teaching;

⁸ Or he that exhorteth, on exhortation: he that giveth, let him do it with simplicity; he that ruleth, with diligence; he that sheweth mercy, with cheerfulness.

- Elsewhere, G4234 appears as “deed(s)”, and “works”.
- Take note that in **Rom 12:4-8** & **1Co 12:27-30**, the word “evangelist” is absent. That’s because the local body of Christ has no need for evangelists for itself. Therefore, both of those passages deal with the “local assembly”.
 - The Biblical definition of evangelist (not to be conflated with *the training of* or *the gift of*) can be obtained by looking at the *actions* of the only man in Scripture that is explicitly called an evangelist: Philip (not the apostle; **Acts 8:1-5, 21:8**):
 - Travel, proclaiming the gospel of Christ.
 - **Acts 8:5,12,40, 21:8**
 - Obey the Spirit’s guidance.
 - **Acts 8:26-35**
 - Use the Scriptures to prove Jesus.
 - **Acts 8:30,35**
 - Baptize new converts.
 - **Acts 8:12,38**

So, if **Romans 12** doesn’t even mention “evangelist” why is it the foundational verse for this study? For one decisive reason: **Rom 12:4** establishes a universal rule that not every member has the same office (or *praxis* G4234 – function, deed, or work).

By itself **Rom 12:4** directly answers the question, “Are all evangelists?” with a clear, structural **No**. However, because tradition can become deeply embedded in how we read and interpret the Scriptures, more work must be done to root it out and replace it with truth.

Summary of gifts (members and offices) and spiritual gifts

Attribute	Ephesians 4:8-13	1 Corinthians 12:1-13	Romans 12:4-8	1 Corinthians 12:27-30
What is Given?	Men as gifts (offices/leaders given to the Church)	Spiritual gifts	Functional gifts given to individual members	Positions set directly <i>in</i> the local church body
Giver / Source	Ascended Christ	The Holy Ghost	God	God
Primary Scope / Direction	Global & Outward expansion (building, edifying, and adding to the universal Body)	Individual & Internal (every member functioning within the local assembly)	Individual & Internal (practical, everyday service and conduct within the local assembly)	Corporate & Internal (the structural ordering of the local church assembly)
Key Distinctions	Includes evangelists and pastors; bound by a clear temporal framework	Spiritual manifestations; no temporal boundary in text	Omits evangelists; retains teachers and administrative/support roles	Omits evangelists; retains teachers and administrative/support roles

Take special note that in [Eph 4:8-13](#), they are called “*gifts*” and they are not called “*spiritual gifts*” as in [1Co 12:1-12](#) which has no temporal framework limitation like [Eph 4:8-13](#) but instead is governed simply by the presence of the Holy Ghost. This is a **very important** distinction for many reasons and only some of them are covered in the above table.

As we have already covered in a previous study entitled “What is an apostle?” (<https://cheerful-wmcdannell.wordpress.com/2026/07/25/what-is-an-apostle/>) the **gifts** that Christ gave at His ascension “*for the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ*” will all continue to be given until the body of Christ reaches full maturity ([Eph 4:13](#) “*Till...*”).

If one rejects the explicit grammatical duration established by that temporal clause (“*Till...*”), it reveals a willingness to override plain text in favor of ecclesiastical tradition. Recognizing these explicit boundaries of English grammar and syntax is essential for accurately understanding the distinct roles established throughout the New Testament.

Tense Matters

Colossians 1:21-23

²¹ And you, that were sometime alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath he reconciled

²² In the body of his flesh through death, to present you holy and unblameable and unproveable in his sight:

²³ If ye continue in the faith grounded and settled, and be not moved away from the hope of the gospel, which ye have heard, and **which was preached to every creature which is under heaven**; whereof I Paul am made a minister;

The key takeaway here is that “*which was preached*” is **past tense** (a completed historical action) and “*whereof I Paul am made a minister*” is **present tense** (an ongoing state of office). This tense disjunction alone separates the historical proclamation from Paul’s present ministry.

Furthermore, that past-tense, completed action **does not** include Paul as an agent. This is demonstrated by the pronominal adverb “whereof” (functioning as the prepositional phrase “of which”). It anchors Paul as a minister of *the gospel* itself (the antecedent noun), rather than making him a participant in the past verb phrase (“*was preached*”). That is to say, Paul is a minister of the gospel resulting from that prior action, in which he took no part.

Here is a table that shows the grammatical relationship of the noun phrase that governs all three relative clauses:

Governing noun phrase	The hope of the gospel		
Relative clauses	Which ye have heard	Which was preached...	Whereof I Paul...

So if Paul was not part of that completed action, as the grammar plainly shows, who did complete it? Testing this against the rest of Scripture, there is only one group of men who were given that universal command (**Mark 16:15**), **and** it is also explicitly recorded elsewhere in the *past tense* that they fulfilled it (**Mark 16:20**).

But, before we look at **Mark 16** let’s first look at all of the “parallel” passages for it.

Selective Grammar

Matthew 28:16-20

- ¹⁶ Then **the eleven disciples** went away into Galilee, into a mountain where Jesus had appointed **them**.
¹⁷ And when they saw him, **they** worshipped him: but **some** doubted.
¹⁸ And Jesus came and spake unto **them**, saying, **All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.**
¹⁹ **Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost:**
²⁰ **Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you** **always, even unto the end of the world. Amen.**

I've highlighted the entire anaphoric co-reference chain (pronoun → antecedent) all the way back to **who exactly** Jesus gave these commands to. In this context, these commands were given **only** to "*the eleven disciples*". Because God did not give these commands to anyone else, applying them to **any** other person based on this passage commits a scope fallacy (or an unwarranted generalization), violating the grammatically restricted context of the passage.

It's exactly the same error as applying what Jesus said in **Mat 5:20**, **Mar 4:40**, **Luk 12:56**, or **Joh 13:14** to every Christian today. Who defines the limits of what does and does not apply when we do this? It's not the word of God.

Furthermore, when applying "The Great Commission" to every Christian this passage isn't even applied in its entirety, as the grammar demands, which should be a clue that we're making an error (colloquially known as cherry-picking). If we want to apply this to every Christian then all of the following necessarily apply:

1. **Every one** must go to **all nations** and teach them everything that Jesus **personally** commanded them.
2. **Every one** must go to **all nations** and baptize them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.

This selective application could be termed "selective grammar," but it is more commonly recognized as cherry-picking. Uncritical extraction fails the Biblical standard to "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good" (**1Thess 5:21**) because such an interpretation relies on authority outside of what the text itself permits.

The Great Omission

Luke 24:45-48

⁴⁵ Then opened he their understanding, that they might understand the scriptures,

⁴⁶ And said unto them, Thus it is written, and thus it behoved Christ to suffer, and to rise from the dead the third day:

⁴⁷ And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations, beginning at Jerusalem.

⁴⁸ And ye are witnesses of these things.

The two disciples on the way to Emmaus are told that they are witnesses of these things:

1. Christ suffered and rose from the dead.
2. Repentance and remission of sins should be preached in his name among all nations.

Why did Jesus word it exactly this way? Because the command to do the preaching among all nations **wasn't given to these two**. They were **witnesses of the preaching** and not ministers of it in particular. Sometimes, what is not written can be just as important as what is written.

Proponents of applying "The Great Commission" universally fail to account for passages like this because the explicit grammatical distinctions in Scripture contradict a one-size-fits-all model.

Side note: This grammatical context, together with the rest of Scripture, also confirms that the unnamed disciple with Cleopas was not one of the eleven.

Uncertain Terms

John 20:19-23

¹⁹ Then the same day at evening, being the first day of the week, when the doors were shut where **the disciples** were assembled for fear of the Jews, came Jesus and stood in the midst, and saith unto them, **Peace be unto you.**

²⁰ And when he had so said, he shewed unto **them** his hands and his side. Then were **the disciples** glad, when **they** saw the Lord.

²¹ Then said Jesus to **them** again, **Peace be unto you: as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you.**

²² **And when he had said this, he breathed on them, and saith unto them, Receive ye the Holy Ghost:**

²³ **Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain, they are retained.**

²⁴ But Thomas, **one of the twelve**, called Didymus, was not with them when Jesus came.

²⁵ The **other disciples** therefore said unto him, We have seen the Lord. But he said unto them, Except I shall see in his hands the print of the nails, and put my finger into the print of the nails, and thrust my hand into his side, I will not believe.

Tracing the anaphoric co-reference chain in this passage reveals that Jesus delivers the command, "**as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you**," to the antecedent noun phrase "*the disciples*."

This passage is actually the strongest support for "The Great Commission applies to every Christian today" because "*the disciples*" is not explicitly defined in this context. Meaning, we have no idea exactly *which/how many* disciples the command "**...as my Father hath sent me, even so send I you**," applies to in this context.

Yet, proponents of a universal commission almost never cite **John 20:21** to build their case. Why? Because strict grammatical consistency requires that the entire pronominal chain be kept intact. If the "you" of verse 21 ("**even so send I you**") applies universally to every Christian, then the "ye" of verse 23 ("**Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted...**") must also apply universally.

By refusing to use **John 20** as their foundation, commentators unwittingly demonstrate that they recognize the danger of expanding indefinite antecedents when the surrounding authority exceeds what they are willing to grant to every believer. And yet, that is exactly what is required to apply **Mark 16:15** to all Christians.

Commission Impossible

Mark 16:14-20

- ¹⁴ Afterward he appeared unto **the eleven** as **they** sat at meat, and upbraided **them** with **their** unbelief and hardness of heart, because **they** believed not them which had seen him after he was risen.
- ¹⁵ And he said unto **them**, **Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.**
- ¹⁶ **He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned.**
- ¹⁷ **And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues;**
- ¹⁸ **They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover.**
- ¹⁹ So then after the Lord had spoken unto **them**, he was received up into heaven, and sat on the right hand of God.
- ²⁰ And **they** went forth, and **preached every where**, the Lord working with **them**, and confirming the word with signs following. Amen.

I have highlighted the co-reference chain so the grammar can plainly represent itself. The command in verse 15 is given **specifically** to “*the eleven*”. Nowhere in the context does Scripture expand the definition of “ye” to anyone else. Therefore, placing that command on anyone else is a fallacy of distribution (scope fallacy or unwarranted generalization).

Verses 16-18 seem to be indiscriminate (or indefinite) at first glance, but they are not. They only necessarily apply to those that believe *what the disciples were commanded to preach* (because “*he that believeth*” is grammatically governed by “*the gospel* [preached by the eleven]”).

Notice that the phrase “*preached every where*” in verse 20 is **past tense**, exactly matching Col 1:23! Without Mark 16:20, Col 1:23 is left without its historical fulfillment anchor in Scripture. The command given to “*the eleven*” was completed before their deaths, and that completion is confirmed in Col 1:23.

Textbook Cherry-picking

“Cherry-picking” is defined as extracting a phrase, verse, sentence, or verses from its context and then interpreting it in isolation.

That is precisely what is required to apply “The Great Commission” to every Christian today. This is easy to demonstrate using basic grammar and simple logic: verse 15 is pulled out of its context, applied to all Christians, while the **remainder of verses 16-18 are ignored**.

Why? Because by testing Scripture against reality we can observe that verses 16-18 do not manifest in every Christian. This forces interpreters to ignore basic grammar and chop the passage into arbitrary slices that God never divided, creating a logical fallacy and thus departing from the truth.

What happens grammatically to verses 16-18 when we apply verse 15 to all Christians? Verses 16-18 are then **required** to apply to **anyone** who believes the gospel preached by **any** Christian at **any** time.

You can easily test this grammatically and practically: lay your hands on anyone who is sick and if **every single one** of them does not recover as a **direct result**, then verse 18 doesn't apply to you. And if verse 18 doesn't apply to you, then the grammar dictates that neither does verses 15-17.

Rightly dividing the word of truth

As we can plainly see and test for ourselves, ignoring the basic grammar of a passage creates serious, unresolvable problems. Let's see what happens when we do not ignore the grammar.

Verse	Subject / Pronoun	Antecedent	Direct Grammatical Link
14	"the eleven"	Primary Noun Phrase	The specific audience present: "they" / "them"
15	"Go ye"	"them" (v. 14)	Jesus speaks directly to the eleven (<i>them</i> → <i>ye</i>)
15	"preach the gospel"	Imperative Command	The specific action assigned to "ye" (the eleven)
16	"He that believeth"	"the gospel" (v. 15)	Defines the recipient who responds to <i>the gospel preached by the eleven</i>
17	"them that believe"	"He that believeth" (v. 16)	Plural subject encompassing those who accept the preached gospel of the eleven
18	"They", "them", "they"	"them that believe" (v. 17)	Attaches the signs (<i>serpents, deadly things, healing</i>) directly to those believers

Notice how, when we analyze a passage in its immediate context, each subject and pronoun resolves itself perfectly. There is no ambiguity in this interpretation because we are allowing Scripture to define its own scope. There also is no longer contradictions with the rest of Scripture, for example [Eph 4:8-13](#), which clearly defines four distinct, continuous gifts for the building of the body of Christ. And lastly, we are no longer required to ignore the simple grammar of other passages in order to force things to fit together – instead, they just fit together perfectly on their own.

Furthermore, now we can now search elsewhere in Scripture for individuals who fit directly into the grammatical requirements of verse [17](#) because they are explicitly recorded as displaying those specific signs listed in verses [17-18](#):

- **Paul** (Saul of Tarsus)
 - Although he did not receive the gospel from the eleven ([Gal 1:11-12](#)), he was specially commissioned by Jesus Christ Himself with "equal" authority ([Acts 9:26-28](#)), as evidenced by the signs done by himself **and** those that believed his preaching.
 - Casting out devils, speaking with new tongues, taking up serpents, laying hands on the sick for recovery ([Acts 16:18, 19:6,11-12, 28:3-5,8-9, 1Co 14:18](#))
- **Philip** the evangelist
 - Casting out devils, laying hands on the sick for recovery ([Acts 8:5-7](#))
- **Ananias** of Damascus
 - Laying hands on the sick (G732 *árrhōstos*) for recovery
- **Cornelius** and his household
 - Speaking in new tongues ([Acts 10:46](#))
- **The disciples at Ephesus**
 - Speaking with new tongues ([Acts 19:1-6](#))

The fact that we do not see these signs operating universally today in every Christian now makes complete sense: those commands **and** those validating signs were not given to every Christian. The tradition has no explanation for that discrepancy that doesn't violate the simple grammar of the passage.

Conversely, if we alter the primary noun phrase in the table above from "the eleven" to "every Christian" (which is required to apply verse [15](#) universally), the grammar demands that **everyone** who believes the gospel preached by **any** Christian **must** exhibit those signs. That fact that we do not see this today should raise red flags that something is wrong with our tradition.

Universal Application

when does “ye” mean “we”?

John 3:1-8

¹ There was a man of the Pharisees, named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews:

² The same came to Jesus by night, and said unto him, Rabbi, we know that thou art a teacher come from God: for no man can do these miracles that thou doest, except God be with him.

³ Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man^{G5100} be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.

⁴ Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man^{G444} be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born?

⁵ Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man^{G5100} be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God.

⁶ That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit.

⁷ Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again.

⁸ The wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.

Co-reference chains:

The Pharisees (v1) ← we (v2) ← Ye (v7)

A man (v1) ← Nicodemus (v1) ← Him (v3) ← thee (v7) ← thou (v8)

a man (v3) ← he (v3) \

\← every one

/

a man (v3) ← he (v3) /

a man (v4) ← he (v4) ← he (v4) ← his (v4)

Notice that Nicodemus and Jesus **do not** use the same noun even though both say “a man”. Nicodemus used a masculine-only noun (as indicated by *his*) whereas Jesus used an indefinite pronoun, which is unbounded by gender or lineage, as proven by His clarifying co-reference in verse 8: “**every one** that is born of the Spirit.”

Scope breakdown

- Universal application (indefinite scope): verses 3, 5, 6 and 8
- Restricted application (specific audience scope): verses 1, 2, and 7

Practical Application

Verses: John 15:1-27

Context: Jesus is speaking to “the eleven” after Judas departed

Co-reference chain Legend:

Jesus Christ, The eleven, God the Father, The world, The Comforter/Spirit of truth/Holy Ghost, Universal

- 1 I am the true vine, and my Father is the husbandman.
- 2 Every branch in me that beareth not fruit he taketh away: and every branch that beareth fruit, he purgeth it, that it may bring forth more fruit.
- 3 Now ye are clean through the word which I have spoken unto you.
- 4 Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me.
- 5 I am the vine, ye are the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: for without me ye can do nothing.
- 6 If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them, and cast them into the fire, and they are burned.
- 7 If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you.
- 8 Herein is my Father glorified, that ye bear much fruit; so shall ye be my disciples.
- 9 As the Father hath loved me, so have I loved you: continue ye in my love.
- 10 If ye keep my commandments, ye shall abide in my love; even as I have kept my Father's commandments, and abide in his love.
- 11 These things have I spoken unto you, that my joy might remain in you, and that your joy might be full.
- 12 This is my commandment, That ye love one another, as I have loved you.
- 13 Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friends.
- 14 Ye are my friends, if ye do whatsoever I command you.
- 15 Henceforth I call you not servants; for the servant knoweth not what his lord doeth: but I have called you friends; for all things that I have heard of my Father I have made known unto you.
- 16 Ye have not chosen me, but I have chosen you, and ordained you, that ye should go and bring forth fruit, and that your fruit should remain: that whatsoever ye shall ask of the Father in my name, he may give it you.
- 17 These things I command you, that ye love one another.
- 18 If the world hate you, ye know that it hated me before it hated you.
- 19 If ye were of the world, the world would love his own: but because ye are not of the world, but I have chosen you out of the world, therefore the world hateth you.
- 20 Remember the word that I said unto you, The servant is not greater than his lord. If they have persecuted me, they will also persecute you; if they have kept my saying, they will keep yours also.
- 21 But all these things will they do unto you for my name's sake, because they know not him that sent me.
- 22 If I had not come and spoken unto them, they had not had sin: but now they have no cloke for their sin.
- 23 He that hateth me hateth my Father also.
- 24 If I had not done among them the works which none other man did, they had not had sin: but now have they both seen and hated both me and my Father.
- 25 But this cometh to pass, that the word might be fulfilled that is written in their law, They hated me without a cause.
- 26 But when the Comforter is come, whom I will send unto you from the Father, even the Spirit of truth, which proceedeth from the Father, he shall testify of me:
- 27 And ye also shall bear witness, because ye have been with me from the beginning.

Entire verses that do not apply universally: 1, 3, 7-12, 14-27 (81%)

Every Word Matters

Just like in [Mark 16:14-18](#), in [John 15](#) Jesus explicitly shifts between two modes (direct address / indefinite). A common error in interpretation arises when we assume that a shift in modes automatically expands the relative clauses to universal application. But, that is not all that is required for universal application. There is one key distinction in the following examples, in this case a single word, that completely changes how they can be interpreted.

John 15:5-7

⁵ I am the vine, ye are the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: **for** without me ye can do nothing.

⁶ If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them, and cast them into the fire, and they are burned.

⁷ If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you.

Notice that the “for” in the final clause of verse 5 is a conjunction and it connects both the indefinite phrase “He that abideth in me...” and the direct address “without me ye can do nothing”. That **single word** permits the expansion of the “law of the Vine” to universal application. This is how extremely important that one word is: without it, the “law of the Vine” applies **only** to “the eleven” (the directly addressed audience).

That word “for” is the exact kind of grammatical bridge that is needed to apply what Jesus said universally **in any context**.

Mark 16:14-18

¹⁴ Afterward he appeared unto the eleven as they sat at meat, and upbraided them with their unbelief and hardness of heart, because they believed not them which had seen him after he was risen.

¹⁵ And he said unto them, **Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.**

¹⁶ **He that believeth and is baptized shall be saved; but he that believeth not shall be damned.**

¹⁷ **And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues;**

¹⁸ **They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover.**

Notice in verse 16 when Jesus shifts modes to the indefinite pronoun “He”. Unlike [John 15](#), this passage lacks a conjunction, relative clause linkage, or any other structural mechanism to bridge from the direct address “the eleven ← ye” to universal application (indefinite).

Because there is no causal conjunction (like “for”) or explanatory particle, the shift from second-person (“Go ye”) to third-person (“He that believeth”) remains syntactically **dependent** on the command in verse 15. Therefore, the third-person statements detail the outcomes for the **specific audience** that hears “the eleven” preach the gospel.

And unlike the traditional interpretation which expands verse 15 universally, this interpretation perfectly explains why **every** single person who believes **any** Christian today that preaches the gospel **does not** have these signs: because the command **and** the grammatically linked signs do not apply to every Christian today.